

FOREWORD



There is a section of the Indian Railway system known as the hill section. This is one of India's mountain railways, though certainly not as famous as Darjeeling Himalayan, Kalka Shimla, or Nilgiri Mountain. This hill section is the Lumding–Halflong–Badarpur stretch and used to be a metre-gauge line, built in the 1890s by what was then Assam Bengal Railway. As the train zigged and zagged, those steam engines had a system of catching, which meant another engine at the rear for pushing. As a child, because my father worked in that part of the world, I recall travelling quite a bit along the hill section. You watched out for tunnels, dark and forbidding. You leant out of the window, heard the gibbons, smelt the smoke, and got coal dust and soot in your hair. On one occasion, the train stopped somewhere and the engine driver, a handkerchief tied around his head and his face covered with soot, came to say hello to my father. My father went up in my esteem. To the children of that generation, an engine driver was a hero. I dare say many boys wanted to become engine drivers then, extremely unlikely today. Have you stood by the side of a railway line at night and seen a train with a steam locomotive thunder past, the red tinge lighting up the driver's face as he shovels coal into the fire? Have you laid a coin on the track, waiting for the train to pass over it and flatten it out?

Those are the bygone pages of history, whiffs of nostalgia for the past and one's childhood. Steam locomotives gave way to diesel and diesel to electric. Every once in a while, a steam engine needed to stop, to top up water and coal, say every 100 miles or 160 km. A stop meant passengers could get down, stretch their legs, and purchase food.